Read and Reflect: Exploring How the Display of User-Generated Content Shapes In-Situ Museum Expression

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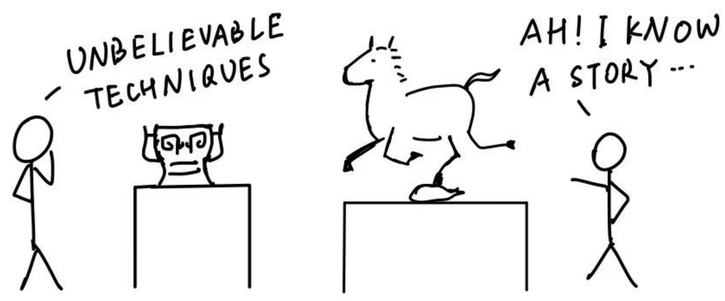
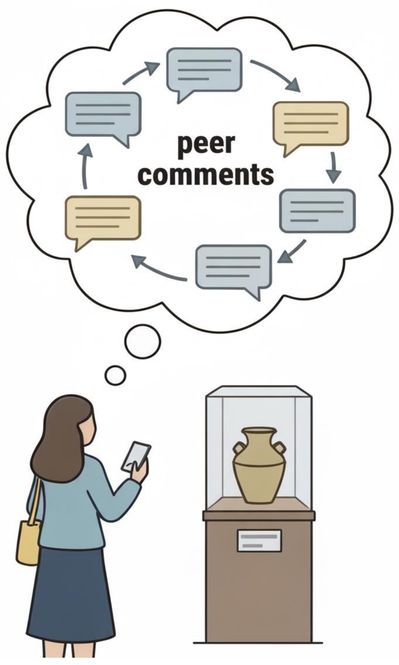
INTRODUCTION

In-Situ v.s. Post-Visit

In-situ expressions are highly contextual but often lost or internalized if not prompted by the environment.





Interpretation-Reflection Loop (IRL)

Engaging with peer perspectives can foster a loop where **interpretation and reflection mutually inform each other**, leading to deeper meaning-making.

The Rise of User-Generated Content (UGC)

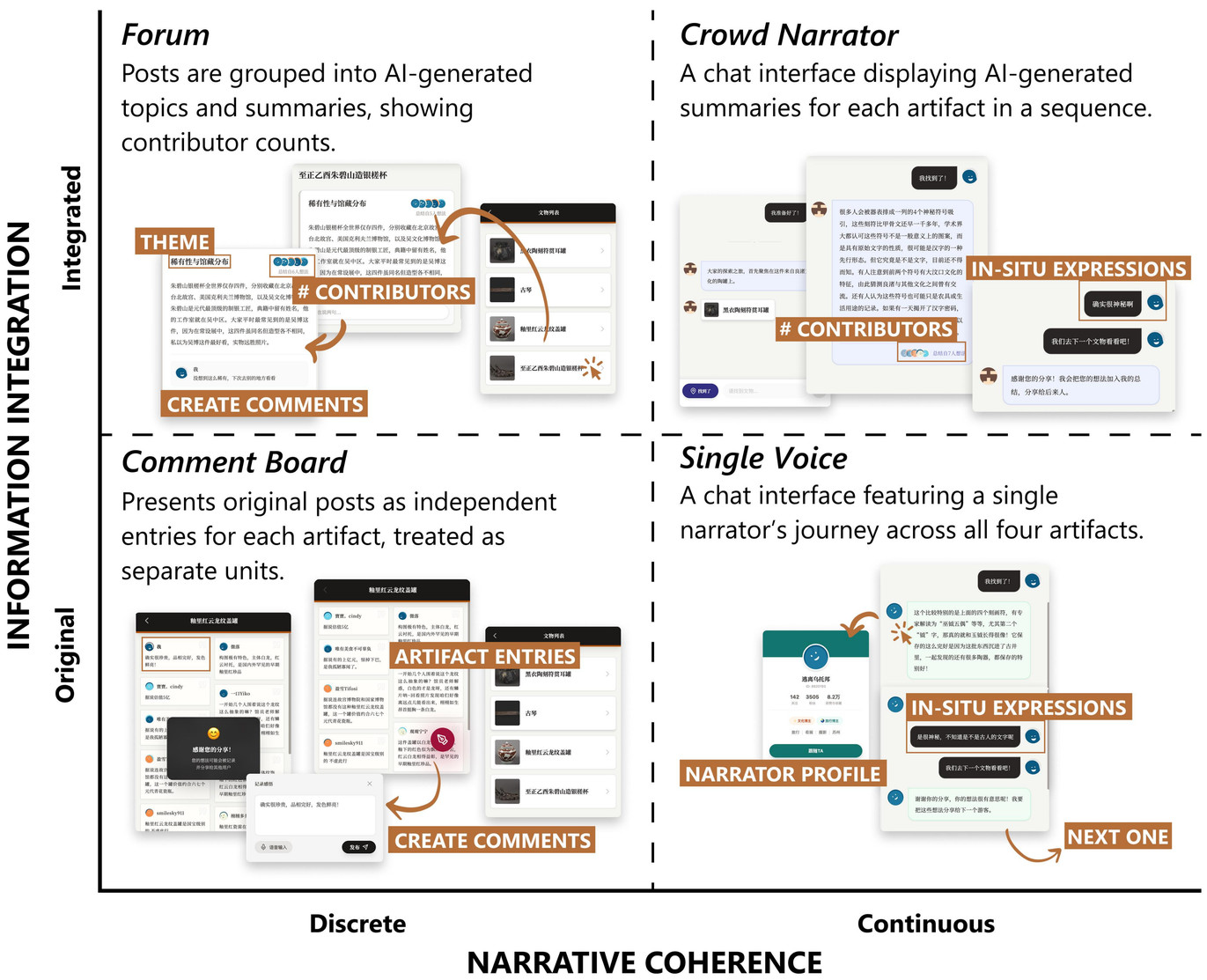
Museums are increasingly collecting visitor comments and reflections, but these are often presented as **fragmented and ephemeral messages**.

Objectives

We aim to explore diverse UGC display approaches and understand how these approaches influence visitor meaning-making and in-situ expressions and reflections.

METHOD & PROTOTYPE DESIGN

- Site: The Museum of Wu (Suzhou, China), focusing on four representative artifacts.
- Participants: 10 participants (aged 29–53) with interests in cultural heritage.
- Procedure: A hybrid design
  - A controlled phase - primary assigned mode
  - A free-roaming phase - switching between modes
  - Semi-structured interviews
- Analysis: Inductive thematic analysis on interview recordings.



RESULTS & DISCUSSION

- User Expectations: Obtaining **additional sources of information** (preferring integrated summaries) and **social connection** (preferring raw content to find resonance).
- Design Dimensions:
  - Information Integration: ***Integrated*** reduce cognitive workload but can feel less "human-like" compared to raw comments.
  - Narrative Coherence: Most visitors prefer ***continuous*** modes as they provide a sense of accompaniment and help link artifacts together.
- **Display Mode Shapes In-Situ Expression**: Chat-based "continuous" modes encourage casual, private expression, while "discrete" public boards trigger cautious, formal, but more frequent self-expression.
- Design Implications:
  - Flexible and Dynamic UGC: Provide integrated UGC displays and allow users to switch modes to match their shifting expectations.
  - Support Graduated Expression: Offer levels of interaction ranging from low-effort (likes) to elaborate personal reflections.

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